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TEXT REVISION AND ANALYSIS

STYLE

PROJECT TITLE

Dominion Peoples Revision

DESCRIPTION

In my Style class, we were assigned several texts to revise to be more clear and concise. This text was from a gas company writing to notify customers of an upcoming rate increase. I was tasked to write an analysis of the original notice that explained the changes I made.

AUDIENCE

Analysis was addressed to the company that issued the notice.

SKILLS DEVELOPED

- Analyzed writing based on principles of clarity and concision
- Explained my revision to the company through a report that detailed the process behind revision

APPLICATIONS USED

- Microsoft Word

DOMINION PEOPLES REVISION

This notice is directed to all customers of Dominion Peoples Gas Company. In particular, the original notice addresses three types of clients - residential, commercial, and industrial. Most customers, especially the residential class, have little experience or interest in the workings of their natural gas provider. Each class of customer will read the notice to understand how it will personally affect them, and they want to quickly and concisely find this information.

This document intends to inform customers about the proposed rate increase, when it will be implemented, how it will affect them, and how they can respond to it. The original document includes all these details, but it contains stylistic and organizational errors that frustrate readers, as evidenced by the amount of complaints Dominion has received. My revision intends to analyze and rewrite the problematic sections of the original, and I will explain my rationale behind these changes. Two main principles guided my revision - main characters should be subjects of sentences, and important actions should be expressed as verbs. We will focus on these two concepts as we edit the original notice in order to help readers comprehend the text.

Stylistic Problem - Characters

We can use the first principle regarding characters to analyze our first important style problem. Put simply, readers like to know who does what in a sentence. When writers can efficiently establish the subject of a sentence it becomes easier for them to convey new information in the latter half of a sentence. Readers comprehend best when writers choose subjects that are the main actors in a sentence. Our goal is to stay away from abstract characters and focus on making the main character the simple subject of each sentence. The first pair of sentences in the original notice break this principle, and have the potential to confuse the reader by not establishing clear characters.

Original

> Dominion Peoples is filing a request with the Pennsylvania Public Utility Commission to increase your natural gas rates as of Oct 1, 2003. This filing is designed to recover the cost of natural gas the Company purchases.

In this paragraph the simple subject varies between Dominion Peoples and the abstract "filing". Our revision hopes to eliminate abstract subjects and facilitate how the reader comprehends the text. This paragraph can be reworded to:

Revision

> Dominion Peoples recently filed a request to the Pennsylvania Public Utility Commission to increase your natural gas rates beginning October 1st, 2003. Dominion proposed the increase to recover costs associated with how it acquires natural gas.

The revision solidifies Dominion Peoples as the agent of both main actions. They file the request and propose the increase. We stay consistent between sentences as we begin to convey the new details about the increase. Authors write clearly when they achieve this consistency, as the reader sees the main character as the simple subject performing actions. There is less work involved when going through the sentence, and that is highly valuable because chances are the customer will have little interest in any content that does not directly affect them. The revision avoids the abstract character of the "filing" and allows the reader to easily follow the main actions of the sentences.

We keep this concept in mind in the example section of the original notice. The original contains multiple instances of abstract characters. The monthly bill becomes the main character of a series of sentences designed to explain how the increase affects each respective class of

customer. The reader is bombarded with information in this section, and to clean it up we can make our customers the simple subject.

Original

> Under Dominion Peoples' proposal, the overall increase in revenues is approximately 23.9 percent, but the change in your bill may vary from this percentage depending on usage and applicable rate schedule. The monthly bill of the average residential customer using 104 mcf per year could increase from $82.55 to $102.29, or by $19.74 per month. The monthly bill of the average commercial customer using 459 mcf per year could increase from $330.81 to $417.93, or by $87.12 per month. The monthly bill of the average industrial customer using 7,650 mcf per year could increase from $4,861.25 to $6,313.28, or by $1,452.03 per month.

In this paragraph there is no clear simple subject. The original notice uses "The monthly bill" and Dominion's "proposal" as abstract characters. The reader can easily become lost in this section, as there is no structure and even irrelevant information. We can examine the sentence to find a better, "flesh and blood" character of the "customer". This is the better choice for our simple subject, as it is a character who performs an action. We avoid any abstractions, and the reader can now follow along with the logical sentence structure.

Revision

> Dominion proposed to increase current rates by approximately 24%, but the change in your bill will vary based on both your usage and your rate schedule.
>
> The average residential customer who pays $82.55 per month could be charged $102.29 per month, an increase of $19.74. A commercial customer who pays $330.81 per month could be charged $417.93. And an industrial customer using 7,650 mcf per year who pays $4,861.25 per month could be charged $6,313.28.

The subject now stays consistent, with Dominion and our customers taking the subject positions. We clearly dictate how the reader's bill may be affected with an example tailored to them. They can find themselves as the subject and follow the logical structure to see how their bill might be affected.

This process is repeated throughout in order to keep paragraphs focused on consistent, "flesh and blood" characters committing actions. We borrow a more narrative like structure to convey the information in the most efficient way possible.

Stylistic Problem - Actions

The original notice also contains problems related to actions and verbs. As discussed, many actions were not concrete and demonstrable by clear characters. This confuses the reader and leads to the complaints we have received. We can further clarify when we focus on the other half of the two principles mentioned above – important actions should be expressed as verbs. The reader fails to understand not only when the subject is unclear, but when the actions taking place are abstract or implied.

The above revisions not only eliminate abstract characters, they delete actions which have been abstracted through the process of nominalization. Nominalization means deriving a noun from a verb or action. The simplest way to convey information is to keep actions verbs, and not let them be hidden away as "characters". For an example, here is a simple nominalization in the original notice.

Original

> Upon request, the Company will inform you of the effect upon your bills.

The reader must do additional work to understand who committed this action. It lies abstract and interrupts the flow of information. We can revise the sentence so that the "effect" is no longer an abstraction, but a concrete action.

Revision

> If you request it, Dominion will inform you how the change affects your personal bill.

We keep the reader in mind and inform them how the rate proposal will "affect" them directly. While a small change, when we make this action direct the reader is forced to do less work. Now that I've explained nominalization, we can look at a more severe change in the notice. Another example can be found in the next paragraph.

Original

> The proposed increase is subject to examination by the Pennsylvania Public Utility Commission, which will schedule hearings to determine the proper rate level to be charged.

Revision

> The Pennsylvania Public Utility Commission will examine Dominion's proposal and schedule hearings to determine the proper rate level.

The PPUC is now the subject of the sentence, and it performs the action "will examine". We remove the empty verb phrase "is subject" and undo the nominalization of "examination". This creates a more logical layout of the sentence and shows our consistent characters and how their interact. When we rely on verbs to express important actions the sentences become more concrete, concise, and clear. The sentences tell more tangible stories and we avoid nominalizations disrupting the sequence of events.

Our revision seeks to put the main characters in an active voice, especially when we write about our customers and what they can do to protest the increase. While not technically wrong, we lose cohesion when using more abstract nominalizations to illustrate actions the reader can perform. For an example, we can assess the following paragraph:

Original

> Forms for the filing of a formal complaint may be obtained by you upon request to the Pennsylvania Public Utility commission, Harrisburg, Penn., 17120. The timely filing of a formal complaint entitles you to participate in a hearing at which you may present testimony and question witnesses of the Company.

The paragraphs leave the filing as an abstraction. The reader would much rather prefer to see in real time their options and how they can act. We can revise this to the following:

Revision

> You may request a form from The Pennsylvania Public Utility Commission to submit a formal complaint. If you file the complaint on time, you will be entitled to participate in a hearing in which you may argue the case against the proposed increase.

The reader is now the subject of the sentences, and actively performs the actions. This should increase readability, as the reader can follow the steps to file the complaint. They can see themselves in the active voice committing the actions and are not left reworking the sentence to understand what to do next.

The abstraction of both subjects and actions are the two most important style problems in the original notice because readers prefer sentences that follow a logical pattern. They wish

to see characters who act in real time over abstract concepts with hard to follow results. The most effective sentences then, are ones in which characters directly perform the stated actions. By identifying the main subjects and main actions, the writer can connect the old, established information to the new in a concise manner. With the revision, we now have consistent characters performing actions instead of an erratic focus and abstractions as subjects. In certain sections the revision uses the reader as the simple subject in order to explain a process or series of events, such as filing a complaint. This should facilitate how readers comprehend the notice and should reduce the amount of complaints Dominion receives.